

3.1 Language change

Paper 3 Language Analysis · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Language changes through contact, technology, identity and shifting social attitudes. Trace a feature across data rather than assuming all change is decay or progress. Analyse spelling, lexis, semantics and grammar using actual evidence; representativeness and dating of sources limit generalisations.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A technology term may broaden from a technical object to a metaphor. Explain the older literal and newer figurative senses and who uses them, instead of merely calling it “new slang”.

Original practice stimulus

Archive extract, 1898: “A stream of workers passed the mill gate every morning.” Modern news extract: “The theatre will stream its final performance to audiences outside the city.” Student message: “My feed is a stream of updates today.” The physical image of moving water appears in contexts of crowds and digital media, but the three samples come from different genres and dates. The spelling in this small collection stays constant even as grammatical roles and associated technology differ. The data do not establish when a newer sense first appeared, how frequent it is, or whether speakers in every variety use it similarly.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Compare the meanings of “stream” in “a stream crossed the field” and “stream the lecture live”. Explain one mechanism of semantic change and one limit of this tiny dataset. [25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong answer identifies noun-to-verb development and metaphor/semantic extension, supports claims with both examples and acknowledges two sentences cannot establish frequency, period or general usage. It separates observation from speculation.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: English Language 9093, 2024–2026.

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/635901-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.